Beyond Data: AI for Human Connection

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Making Reports Useful Again

Dashboards Designed for Decisions

Tuesday, April 21, 2026
3:15 pm

StratusLIVE

Speaker

Making Reports Useful Again

Dashboards Designed for Decisions

Paula Elrod
Project Manager, StratusLIVE

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Agenda

- The Problem with Most Reports
- What Makes a Dashboard Useful
- Anatomy of a Great Dashboard
- Dashboard Examples
- Building Dashboards in StratusLIVE
- Common Mistakes & Pro Tips

The Problem

Why most reports and dashboards fail to drive action

Reports Don’t Drive Decisions

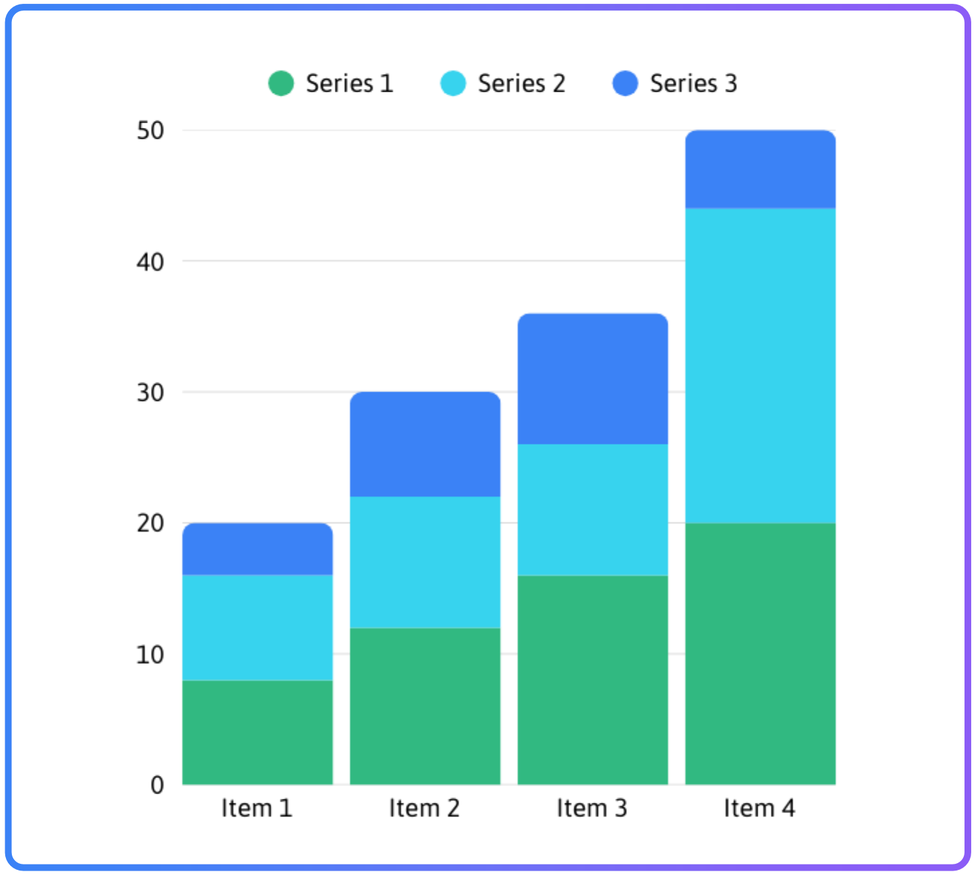
Most reports get opened once – and forgotten

- Too much data, not enough clarity
- Users don’t know what to look for
- No clear next action

The Real Problem

We design for data, not decisions

- Reports answer “What happened”
- Leaders need “What should I do?”
- Dashboards must bridge the gap



Making Dashboards Useful

Principles that drive adoption and impact.

1

Start with Decisions

Dashboards should answer real questions

2

Less is More

Clarity beats completeness

3

The Right Components

Match the visual to the need

4

Design for Roles

Different users need different dashboards

“

A dashboard is not a report summary – it’s a decision tool.

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Anatomy of a Great Dashboard

What Great Dashboards Do

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What Great Dashboards Do

Show What Matters

Focus attention on key metrics

Drive Action

Highlight what needs follow-up

Reveal Trends

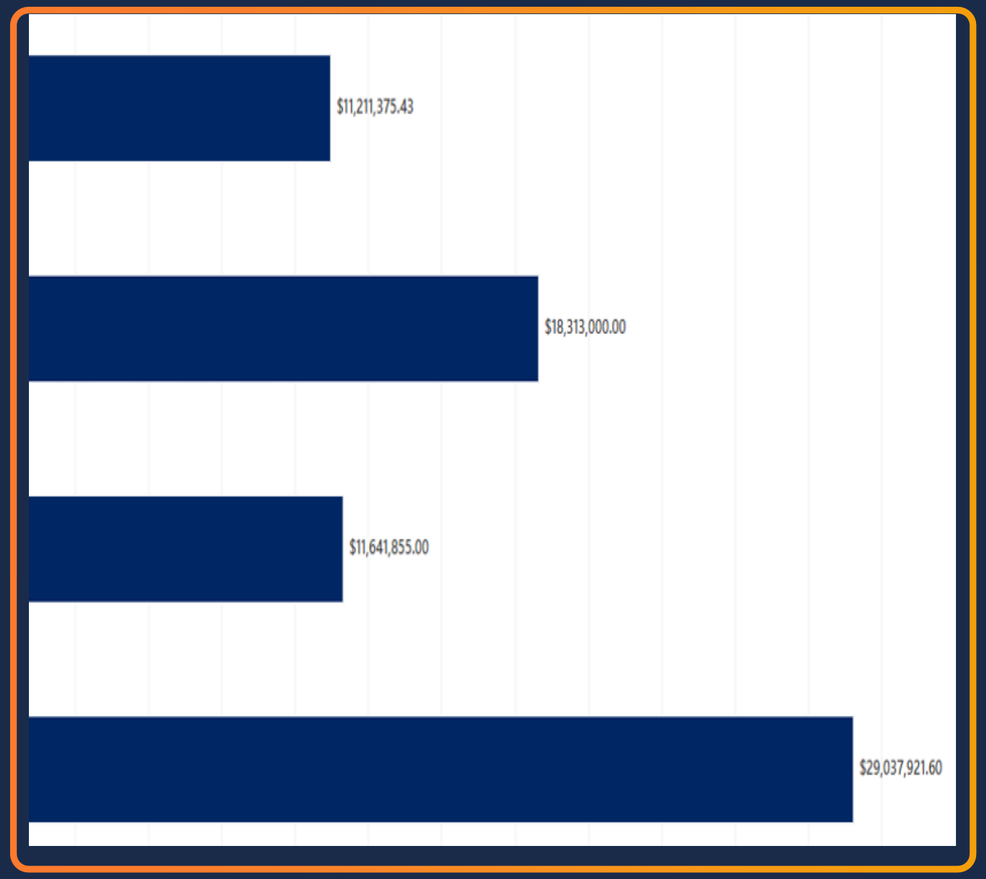
Make change visible over time.

A Simple, Effective Structure

2-3 layers of Insight

- Left, Right or Top and Bottom
- Or Top, Middle and Bottom Section

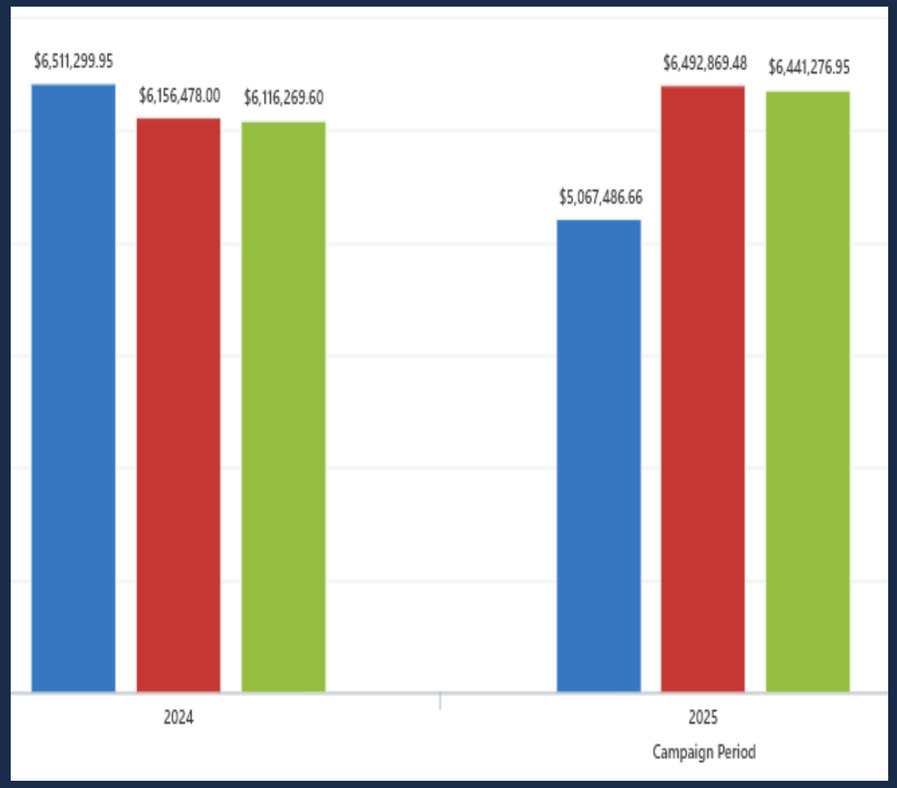
Top Section: KPIs



Answer "Are we on track?"

- Total Raised (YTD)
- % to Goal
- # of New Donors
- Average Gift Size

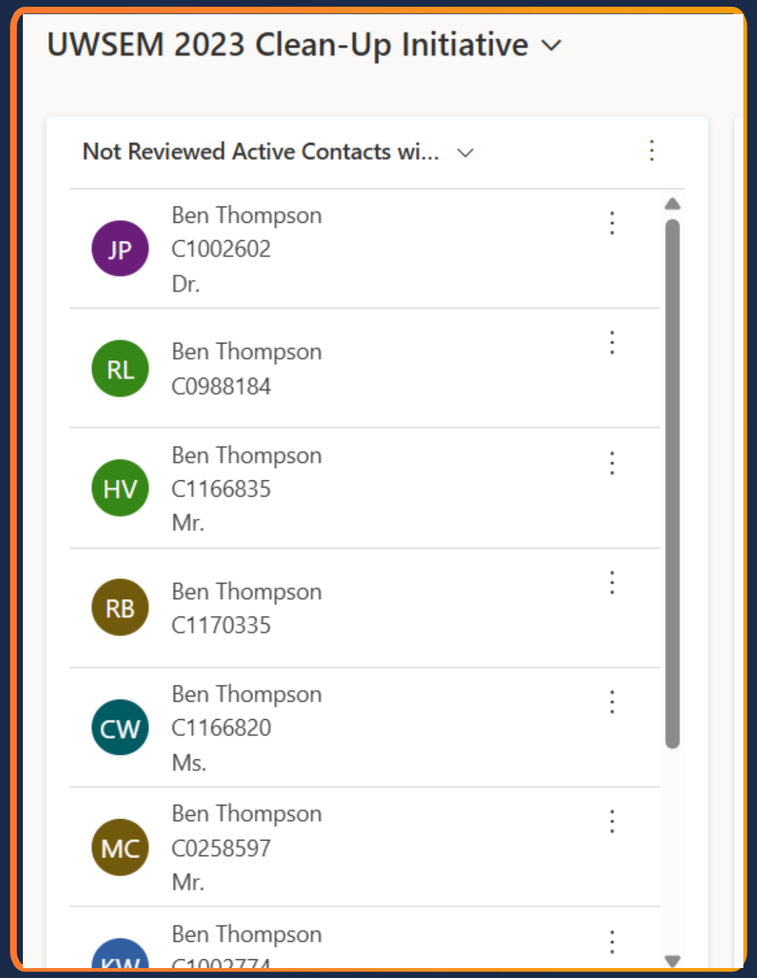
Middle Section: Trends



Answer "What's changing?"

- Revenue over time
- Donor growth/decline
- Campaign Performance

Bottom Section: Action Lists



Answer "What should I do?"

- Lapsed donors
- Open opportunities
- Donors needing follow-up

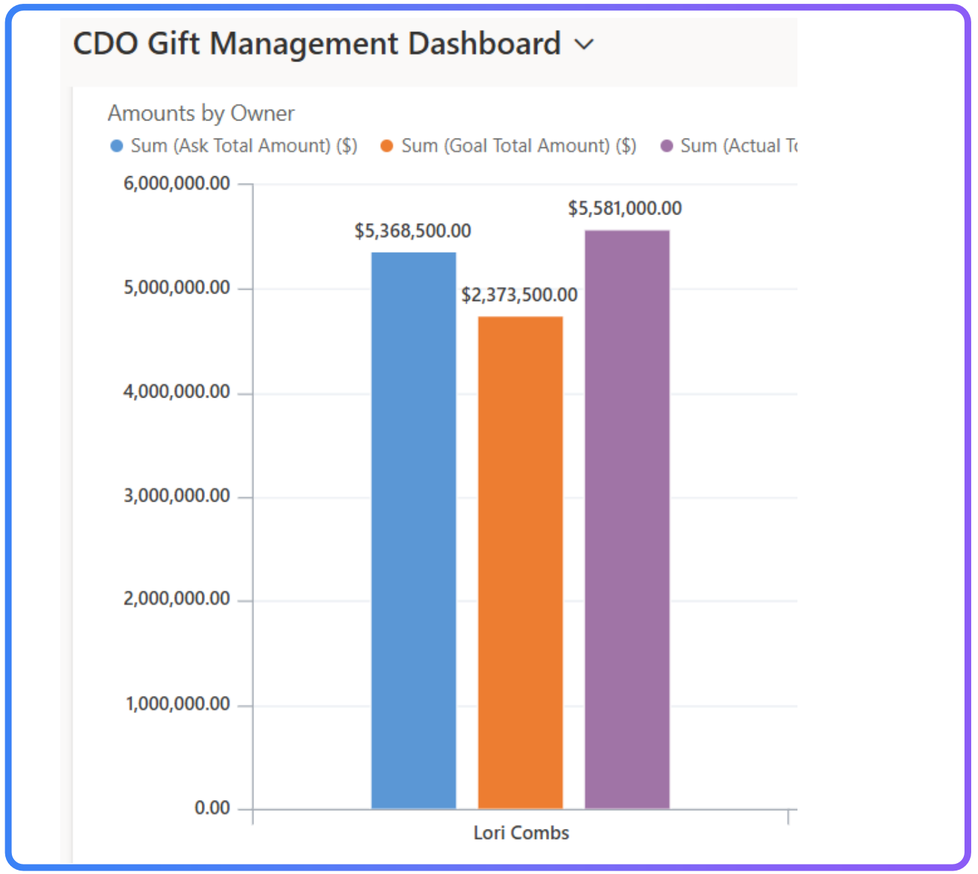
Dashboard Examples

Why most reports and dashboards fail to drive action

Role Specific Dashboard

CDO Gift Management Dashboard

Closed Opportunity Amounts by Owner



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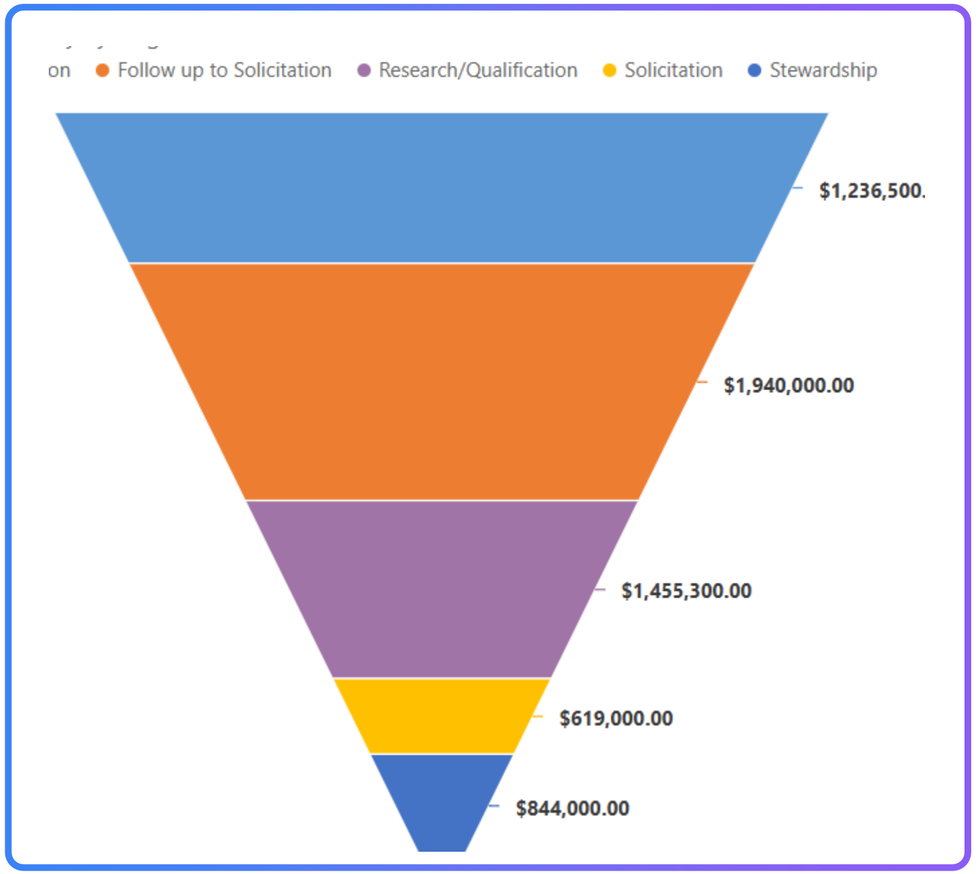
Role Specific Dashboard

CDO Gift Management Dashboard

Opportunities by Process Code/Stage



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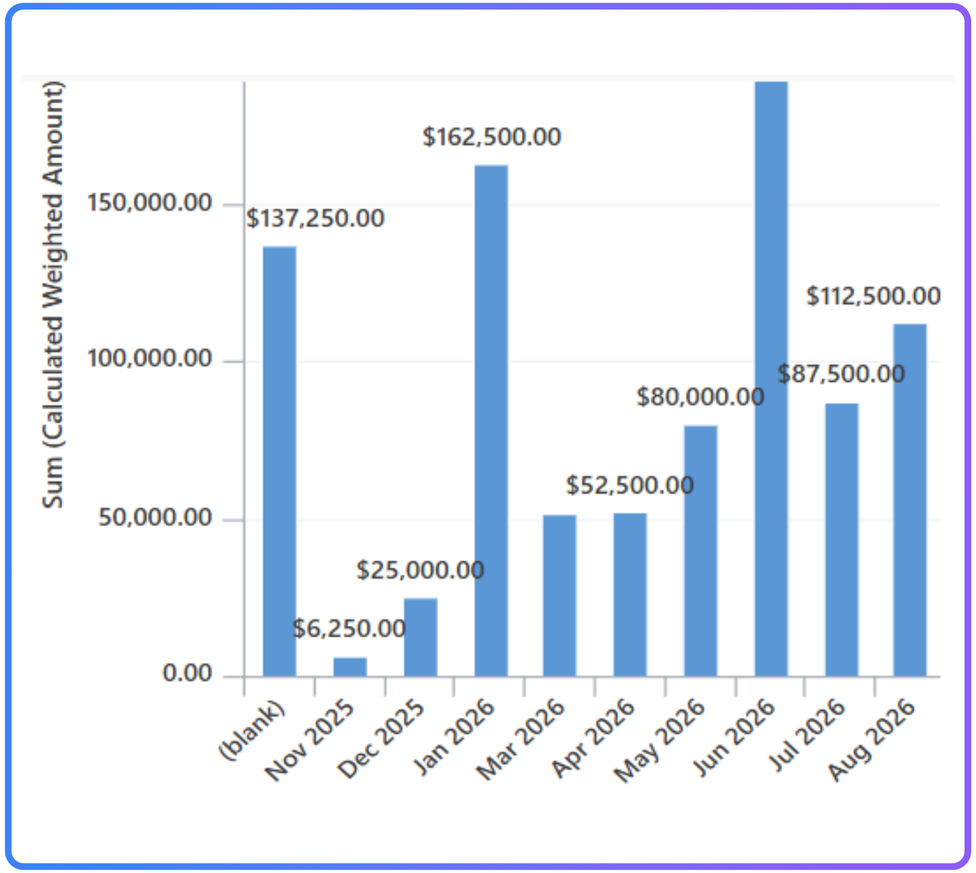
Role Specific Dashboard

CDO Gift Management Dashboard

Weighted Amount by Est. Close Date



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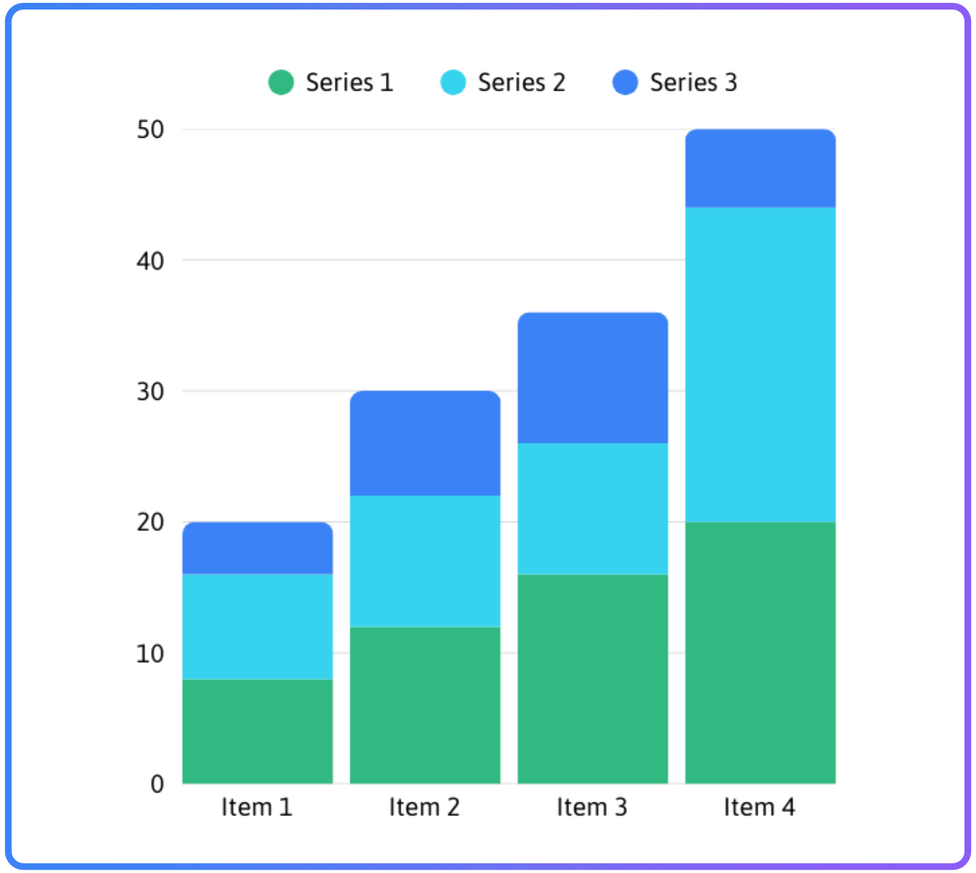
Fundraising Dashboard

Total Raised vs. Goal

- Monthly revenue trends
- Top Campaigns
- Major gift pipeline
- LYBUNT donors



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Fundraising Dashboard Example

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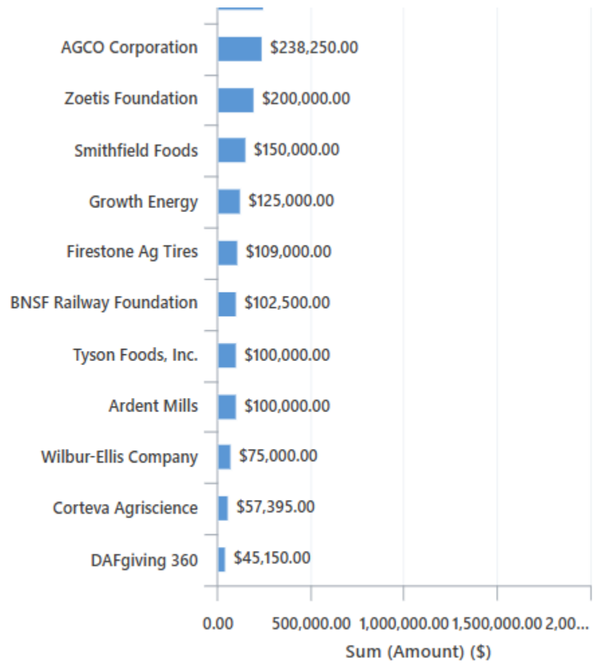
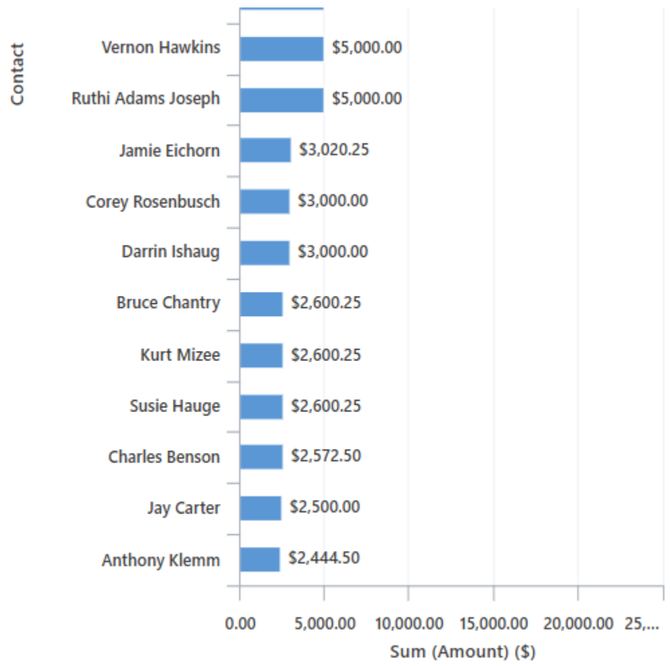
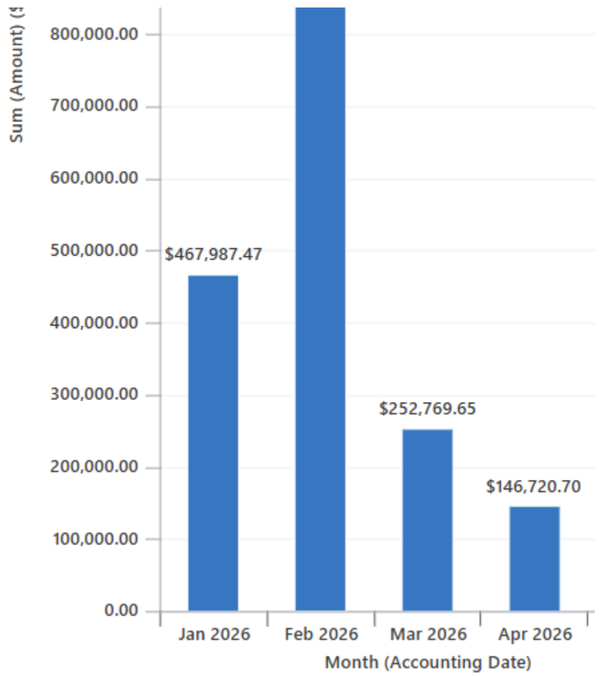
Fundraising Dashboard Example







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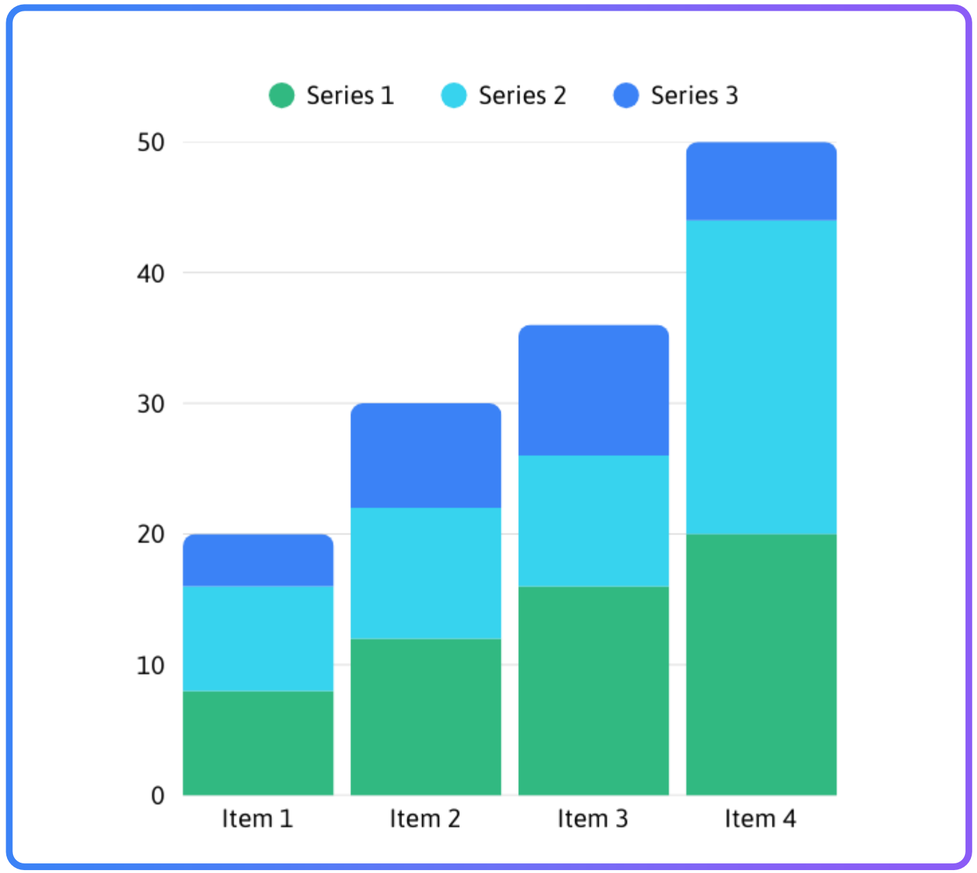
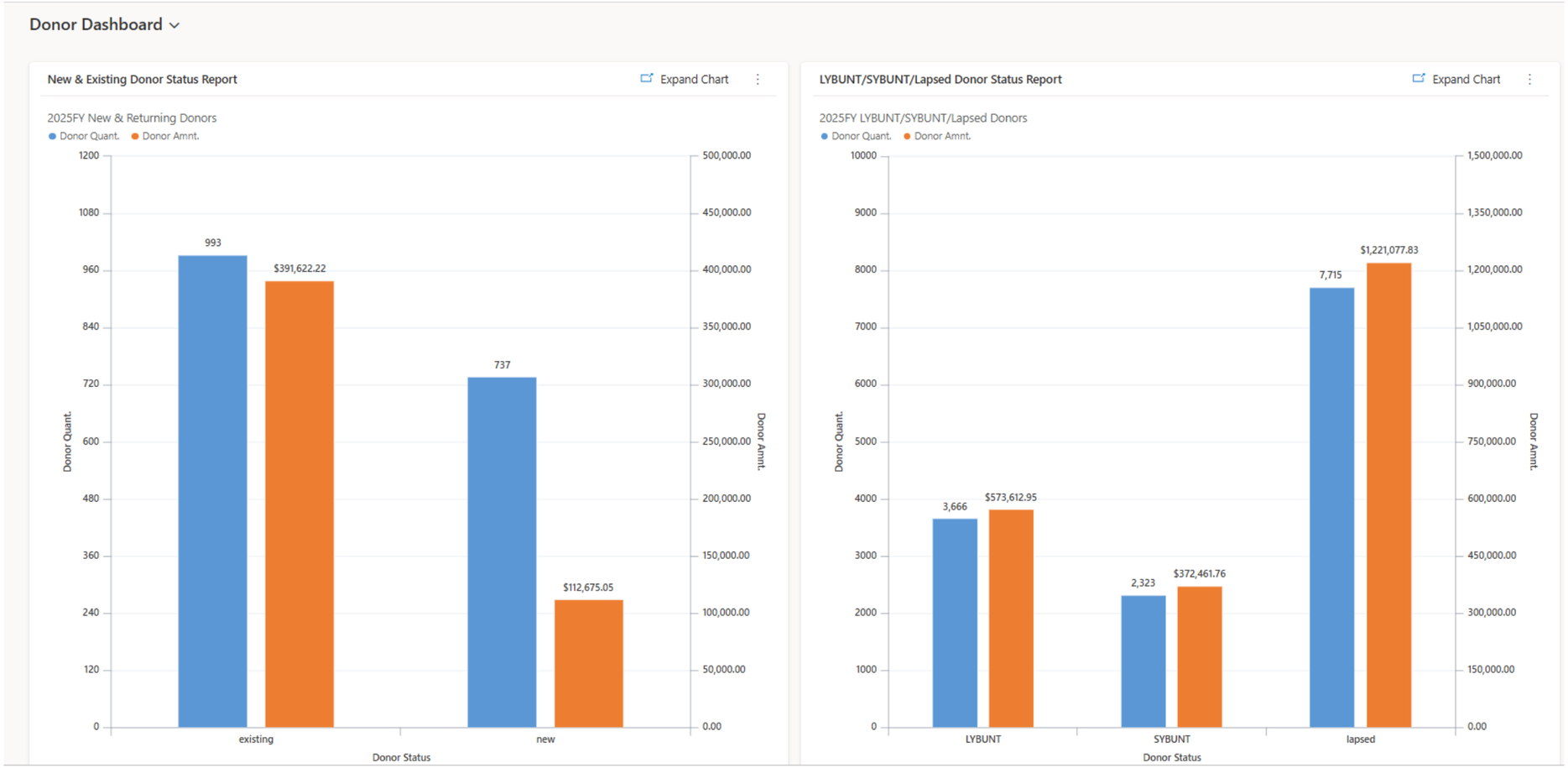
Donor Retention Dashboard



Focus on keeping donors

- Retention rate
- New vs returning donors
- Lapsed donor list
- First-time donor follow-up

Donor Retention Dashboard Example



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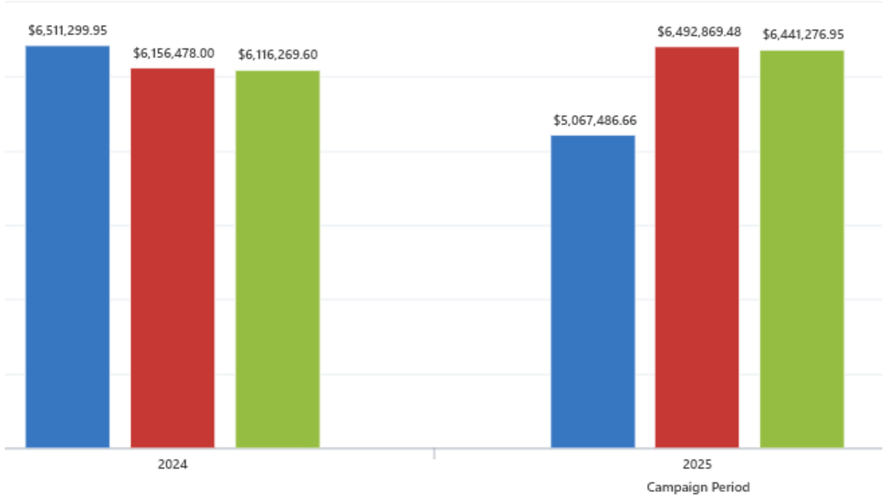
Workplace Giving Dashboard

Know what's working – 3 Year Summary Dashboard

- Special Events and Workplace $
- Goal vs Projected vs Actual $
- Corporate Gifts
- Special Events



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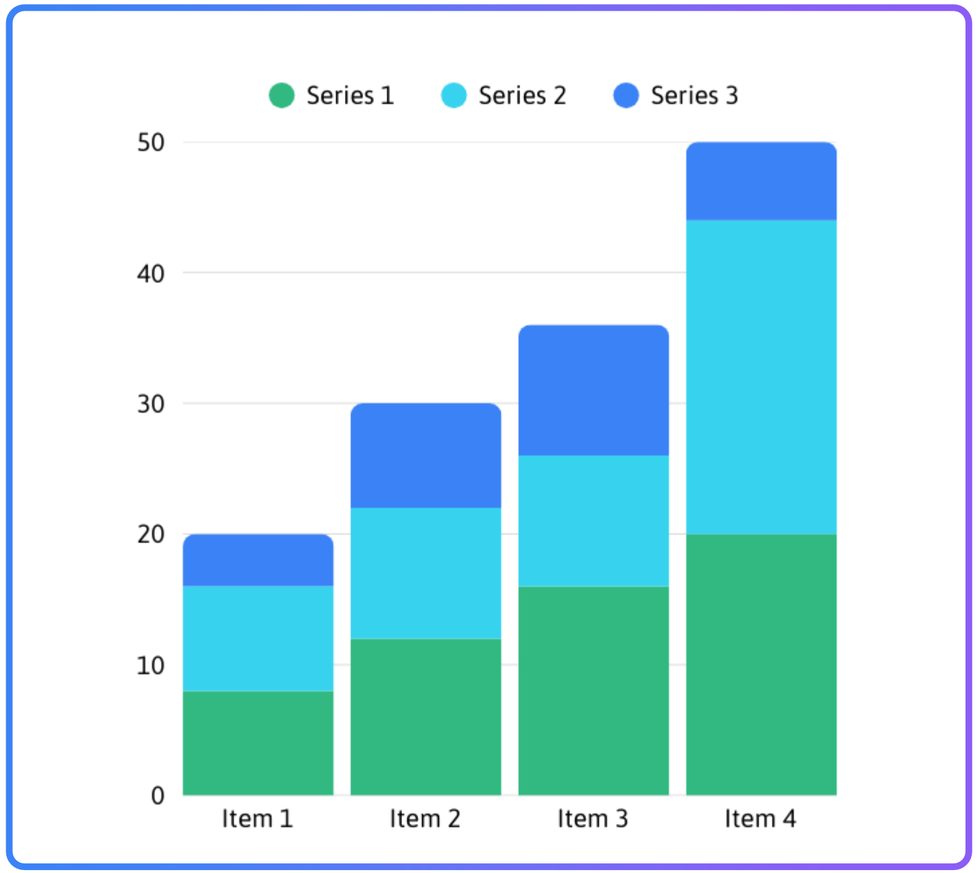
Campaign Performance Dashboard



Focus on Totals

- 3-5 Year Totals
- Leadership Giving Totals
- Highest Campaign identified
- Lowest Campaign identified

Campaign Dashboard Example

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CAMPAIGN ANALYSIS DASHBOARD

View by Campaign Hierarchy

View by Campaign Type

Campaign Status: All

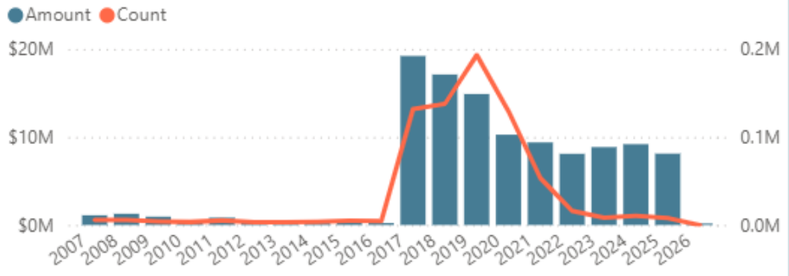
Campaign Category: All

Campaign Period Range: 1/1/2007 – 1/1/2027

Giving Type: All

Type	Direct		Event Registration		Gift		Memo - Payment Bypass		Pa
Campaign Hierarchy	Total Amount	Total Count	Total Amount	Total Count	Total Amount	Total Count	Total Amount	Total Count	To
2026	$27,250.00	3			$259.06	1			
2025	$1,135,051.71	170			$1,383,274.11	3,840			
2024	$266,992.24	112	$18,975.00	50	$951,160.57	2,736			
2023	$339,212.18	154	$53,238.75	166	$16,273.60	213			
2022	$161,356.17	140			$2,463.00	18			
2021	$629,625.61	174			$33,072.31	784			
2020	$297,137.69	155			$26,865.25	2,360			
2019	$342,756.74	268			($21,247.21)	3,817			
2018	$779,470.49	488			$2,175,811.66	6,096			
2017	$488,354.12	319			$2,493,245.14	5,398			
2016	$13,241.21	93							
2015	$25,307.78	64							
2014	$13,104.36	54							
2013	$2,638.07	36							
2012	$20,426.02	80							
Total	**$4,635,468.02**	**2,542**	**$72,213.75**	**216**	**$7,061,177.49**	**25,263**	**$1,505,374.34**	**2,337**	**$**

Donations by Campaign



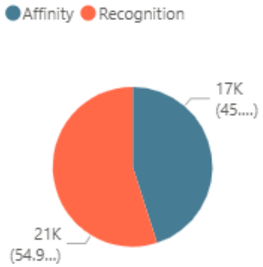
Total Donation Count	Total Amount	Average Donation
730,807	$111,053,446.74	$151.96

Donation Counts

2007		2008		2009		2010		2011		2012		2013		201
#	Avg Gift	#	Avg Gift	#	Avg Gift	#	Avg Gift	#	Avg Gift	#	Avg Gift	#	Avg Gift	#
5,781	$191.60	5,648	$226.33	4,185	$227.63	3,446	$141.35	5,144	$163.50	3,210	$71.83	3,195	$73.48	3,6

Leadership Counts

LevelType		2007	2008	2009	2010	2011	201
Affinity		716	723	755	846	825	9
Recognition	461	186	319	153	367	274	6
Total	461	902	1,042	908	1,213	1,099	1,6



Top Performing Campaign

2017 Hartford Campaign

$16,348,964.33

Least Performing Campaign

2018 Pratt & Whitney HA Corporate Workplac...

($2,716.58)

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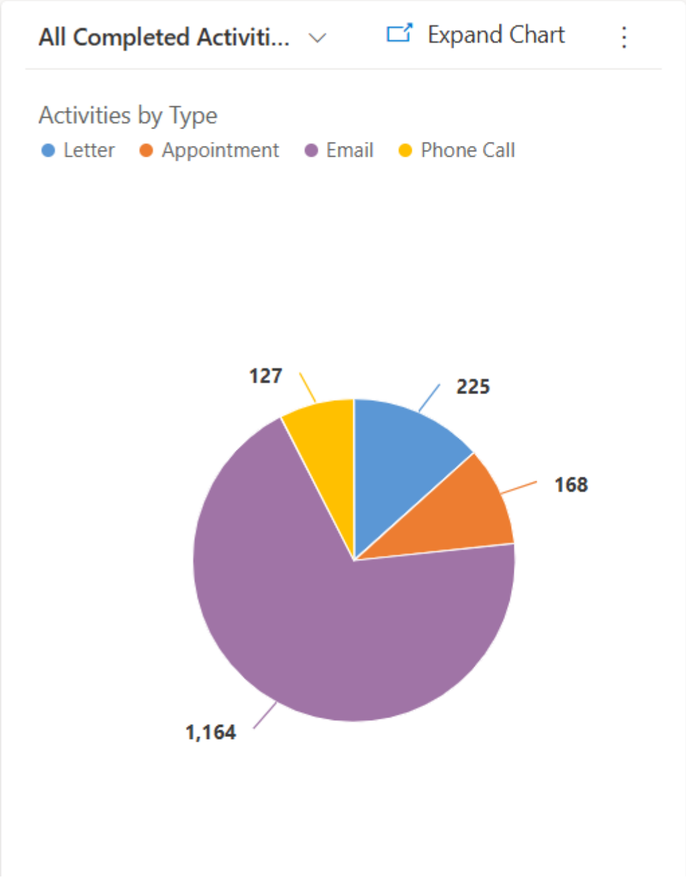
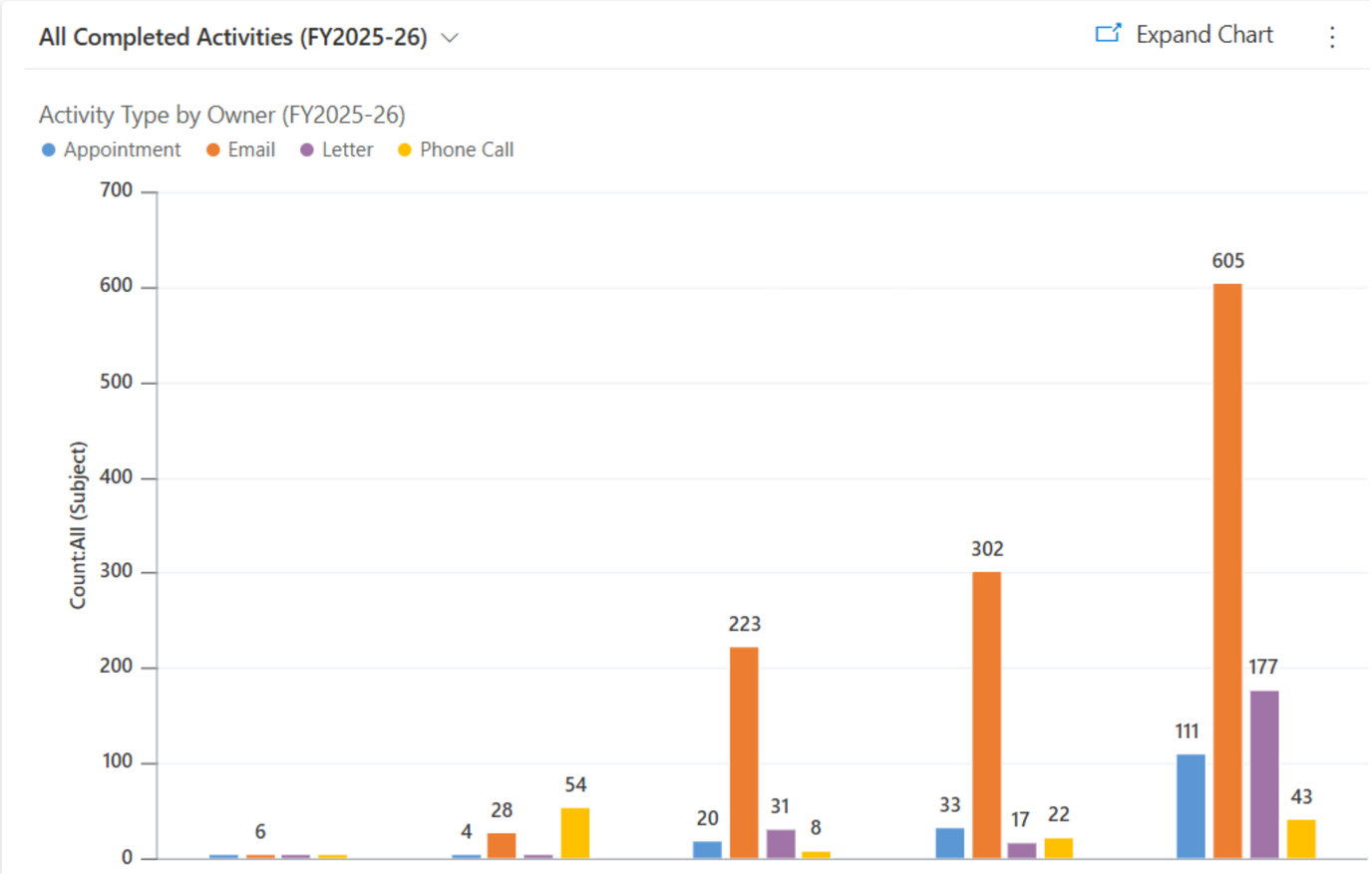
Major Gift Officer Dashboard

Drive daily action

- Portfolio value
- Opportunities closing soon
- Donors not contacted in 30 days
- Pipeline stages

Major Gift Officer Dashboard





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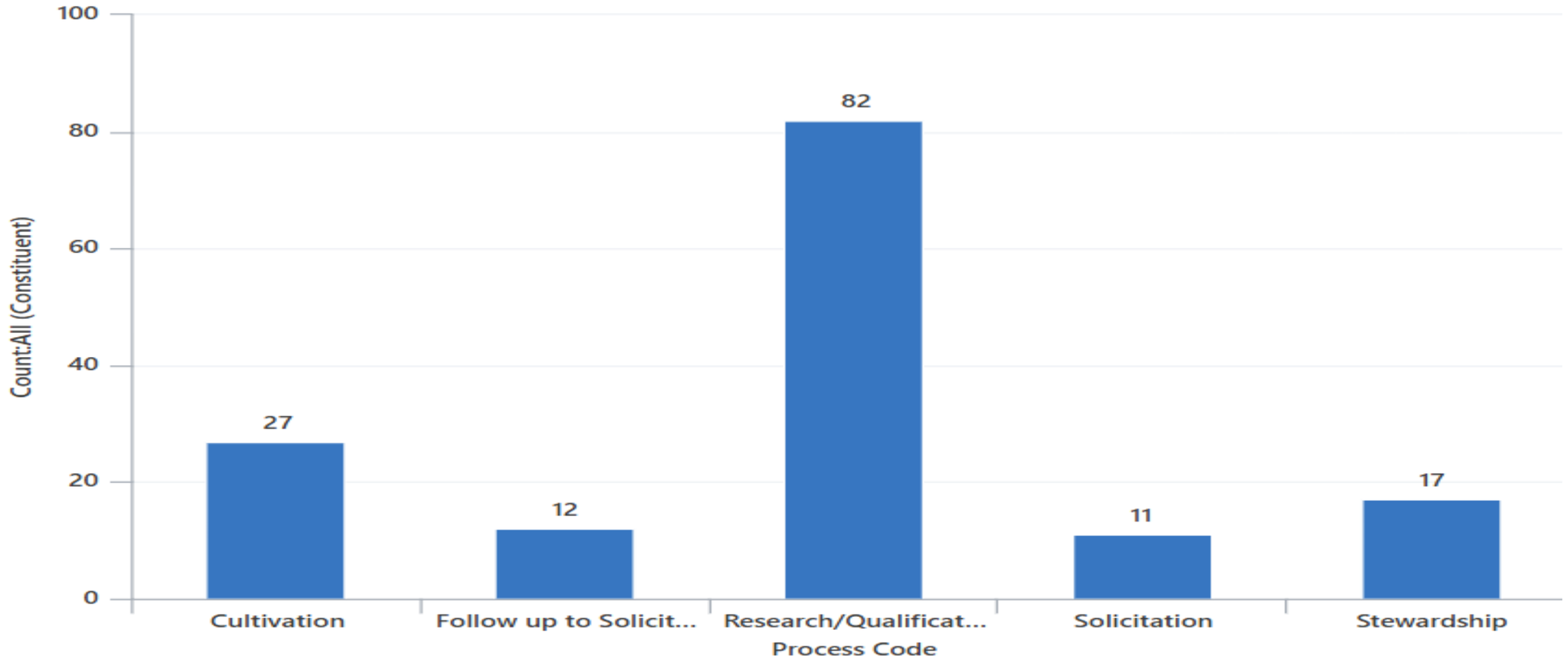
Major Gift Officer Dashboard Example



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Building Dashboards in StratusLIVE

Focus on approach

Dashboards in StratusLIVE

01

Define

Define the Decision

02

Identify

Identify the Data Sources

03

Components

Use the Right Components

04

Keep It Clean

Nothing too complex

Common Mistakes

Dashboards need to project adoption and impact

Transformation

- Too many charts
- No clear purpose
- Same dashboard for everyone
- Static reports

→

- Focused insights
- Decision-driven
- Role-based views
- Evolving dashboards

Dashboard Tips

Design for Decisions

Dashboard Tips

Show What Matters

If it doesn’t change weekly, remove it

Drive Action

Every dashboard needs an action list

Reveal Trends

Executives want trends, staff want tasks

“

Don’t build more dashboards. Build dashboards people can’t do their jobs without.

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Thank You!

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